



THE CATHOLIC CHURCH OF
SAINT MONICA

Wedding Liturgy Guidelines

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CONTACT US

Parish Office

1700 Buford Highway

Duluth GA 30097

Office hours: Monday through Thursday from 10:00 a.m. to 4:30 p.m. or by appointment.

Friday from 10:00 a.m. to 2:00 p.m.

Closed for lunch 12:30 p.m. to 1:30 p.m.

Phone: 678-584-9947

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Clergy

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Director of Communications: Mrs. Madeline Murphy, ext. 121; mmurphy@saintmonicas.com

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Wedding Guild Coordinators: Melissa Dunne, 404-431-0249; madunne@yahoo.com
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PLANNING THE WEDDING CEREMONY

While you are journeying through your pre-marriage instruction program with your Presider, you will also be working with our Facilities Coordinator, Director of Sacred Music, and Wedding Guild Coordinator to plan the details of your ceremony.

If your Presider has not already given you a *packet of readings to choose for your ceremony*, you will receive one at the time when you plan your music. All the readings that you may choose for your Catholic wedding are included in this packet. Spend some time with the scripture, and pray through the readings. Then, once you have made your selections, you will be able to continue in your planning of the music. It's important that you understand the first step in planning your liturgy is the *Word of God* that is to be shared with the community. The music and other elements of the liturgy should reflect those choices.

There are two types of ceremonies: a **Nuptial Mass** (which includes Communion) or a **Ceremony** in which the Liturgy of the Eucharist is excluded. The latter is usually used when either the bride or the groom is not Catholic.

To ensure that all music is suitable for use in Catholic liturgy, all selections must be pre-approved by our Director of Sacred Music & Principle Organist, Jacob Temple, even if someone else is playing for your wedding. He will be happy to coordinate with the musicians who will assist you in choosing beautiful, sacred music that will foster participation and add to the joy and dignity of the occasion.

AVAILABLE DAYS AND TIMES

Weddings at Saint Monica are usually scheduled on **Saturdays at 1:00PM**. Weddings may also be scheduled during the week, subject to availability of the church and clergy.

Weddings may **not** be scheduled during Holy Week, on Sundays, Holy Days, Christmas Eve, Christmas Day, New Year's Eve or New Year's Day, and they are only scheduled during Lent when there are exceptional circumstances. **It is also important to note that during the liturgical seasons of Advent and Lent, flowers are not permitted in the sanctuary.**

The Church is available for **90 minutes prior to the wedding**. In addition, **30 minutes is allowed after a wedding for photographs**. Please understand that there is always a Saturday evening vigil Mass which begins at 4:00pm. Take this into consideration when planning the decor and set-up/take-down required for your 1:00PM wedding ceremony. For this reason, we request that you do not have a receiving line following the wedding.

*****RENTAL OF THE PARISH HALL IS BY SEPARATE CONTRACT AND SEPARATE FEE.*****



MUSIC

The music of your wedding liturgy should be a sacred reflection ideally drawn from the scripture you choose for your ceremony. **Only sacred music is permitted during the liturgy.**

The Church documents on the Sacred Liturgy specifically state that there are parts of the liturgy which are intended to be sung. These include the Gospel Acclamation (which is omitted if it is not sung), the Responsorial Psalm and the Eucharistic Acclamations. (These are sung by the Cantor.)

Although you are not required to retain the services of the Parish Musicians, it is important to understand that a Catholic wedding is not a musical performance but a Sacramental celebration. If you request to have a non-pastoral Musician play or sing, permission will usually be granted for them to play or sing a prelude or two, but the **selections must still be pre-approved by the Director of Sacred Music as appropriate for use in our Church.** These should be either classical selections or songs with prayerful texts that focus on the spiritual rather than physical love.

Although it is true that some secular musicians offer impressive talent and experience, only Catholic Pastoral Musicians have the specialized ministry skills, training and experience necessary to serve as the primary wedding accompanist or cantor. Whether you choose someone who serves in the Music Ministry at *St. Monica's* or another Catholic parish, the services of at least one approved Pastoral Musician must be retained to ensure that the music at your wedding will be both professional *and* prayerful. Jacob Temple or other approved musicians and cantors normally provide the music for all Sacramental Celebrations at *St. Monica's* unless unusual circumstances apply. **(Use of other cantor's or musicians must be approved by Jacob Temple well in advance of the wedding.)**

For the reasons stated above, we require that outside musicians and singers be pre-approved by the Director of Sacred Music, who will advise you of any staff support fees that may apply.

If any music rehearsals are requested outside of the hour preceding the wedding, arrangements must be made in advance between the Director of Sacred Music and all outside singer(s)/musician(s) and will be subject to availability of the church. Additional fees will be determined by the amount of extra time required for each musician.



ALTAR SERVERS

The parish normally provides the altar servers for weddings; unless the couple has requested family members or friends **who are trained as altar servers** to assist. If you intend to provide your own altar server(s), please inform the priest and the Wedding Guild Coordinator well in advance. You may have more than two servers at any wedding, if desired. Please remember that there is a stipend offered to servers. Refer to the Fees and Stipends structure contained in the packet. These are due in full at the final meeting with the Wedding Guild Coordinator.

WEDDING ATTIRE POLICY

The Church is a sacred place. We require that the wedding party be appropriately dressed. Modesty in behavior and in dress is requested. Great sensitivity is required in choosing the wedding dress. There should be no bare shoulders or back, and the hem should reach at least below the knee. If your dress is strapless, you will need to wear a shawl or bolero, (but nothing sheer or see through), for the ceremony. If you have a veil (which is not mandatory), please note that it will **not** be sufficient to cover bare shoulders or back. These guidelines apply to the wedding party as well.

SAINT MONICA'S WEDDING GUILD

Saint Monica offers the services of a Parish Wedding Guild whose members are trained under our guidelines and procedures and work directly with our Clergy and Director of Sacred Music. They will manage the majority of the details regarding decorations allowed in the church, the rehearsal, set-up and flow of the wedding. Members of the Wedding Guild will be present to assist on both the rehearsal and wedding days. Our Wedding Guild Coordinator will usually contact you at least 60 days prior to your wedding, unless you have requested an earlier contact through your Presider, the Director of Sacred Music, or the Parish Office.

If you choose to engage the services of an outside Bridal/Wedding Consultant or Planner, please understand that they **MAY NOT** attend the rehearsal or the wedding ceremony in an official manner, nor do they have the authority to offer any direction or instruction regarding the ceremony. The entire ceremony is under the direction of St. Monica's Clergy, the Director of Sacred Music, and the Wedding Guild member.

FLOWERS

Two Altar Flower Arrangements will be provided by the Church for the wedding day (Except during Advent and Lent). The type of arrangements and color will be determined by *St. Monica's Art & Environment Ministry*. We will attempt to blend with your colors (default color is white). This arrangement will remain at the Church after the wedding. You may purchase additional



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arrangements for St. Mary and St. Joseph, at an additional cost to you. **If seasonal flowers (Christmas, Easter) are in place, they MAY NOT be removed for a wedding.** Please observe the following guidelines with regard to flowers and candles:

1. **Nothing may be removed from or placed on the altar.**
2. Decorations approved by St. Monica's Wedding Guild Coordinator may be placed in the church within 90 minutes before wedding.
3. The decorating must be complete 30 minutes before the wedding is scheduled to begin.
4. All floral decorations not remaining in the church must be removed within 30 minutes after the post-wedding photographs.
5. Tacks, nails, tape, or other means may not be used to secure flowers, greenery, or other decorations to the walls, pews, furniture, or fixtures.
6. Pew bows and Pew bow clips **may** be available for your use. Please check with our Wedding Guild Coordinator.
7. Aisle runners are not permitted in our church due to safety concerns.
8. Nothing may be thrown in the church or on our grounds (no flower petals, rice, bird seed, confetti, etc.) It is preferred that not even silk flower petals be thrown, to ensure the safety of all present.

PHOTOGRAPHY

We understand that photographs are an important memento of your wedding. Yet, we also believe that the dignity and solemnity of the wedding as a Sacrament must be maintained. Please notify your photographer of the following guidelines so that we may all work together to provide a dignified atmosphere to your wedding:

1. **The photographer is allowed one hour before the ceremony for pictures and 30 minutes afterwards.**
2. **Once the ceremony begins, photographs may only be taken from the back of the church.**
3. **No pictures may be taken from the front of the Sanctuary.**
4. **Flashes and/or additional lighting are not permitted during the ceremony.**
5. **Please ask that your relatives and guests refrain from taking pictures once the liturgy begins.**
6. **The Photographer should be dressed appropriately for a formal church wedding.**

Cell phone camera flashes, the noise of various types of equipment and the movement of the photographer are very distracting and diminishes the integrity of the Sacred Liturgy. The Wedding Guild member will also point this out to any guest she sees with a camera.

The Photographer is required to review these rules and agree by signature to these guidelines. (See the attached Photographer Agreement.)



We reserve the right to ask any photographer in violation of these regulations to correct the violation immediately or leave the premises. No exceptions will be made. Violations of this policy will result in the forfeiture of the Compliance Deposit. (See Fees and Stipends on last page.)

VIDEOGRAPHY

Livestreaming your wedding is an available option offered through the church and can be viewed on a YouTube channel. You may request to use this service for a small fee.

If you are having your wedding videotaped, please advise your videographer as to the following parish guidelines:

- 1. All video equipment must be completely set up at least 30 minutes prior to the wedding.**
- 2. The camera must be set up in the back of the church, but not in the sanctuary area of the Church, or in the choir loft.**
- 3. Once in place, the equipment may not be moved during the ceremony.**
- 4. No floodlights or special lighting may be used during the ceremony.**
- 5. No wire may be laid across the aisles.**
- 6. Nothing may be affixed in any way to church walls or furnishings.**
- 7. Only one person may videotape the wedding once it begins (when the groom's mother enters).**
- 8. They may not tamper with or connect anything to the sound system of the church.**
- 9. Any person operating video equipment should be dressed appropriately for a formal church wedding.**

Please make these regulations known to your Videographer. The Videographer is required to review these rules and agree by signature to these guidelines. (See the attached Videographer Agreement.)

We reserve the right to ask any Videographer in violation of these regulations to correct the violation immediately or leave the premises. No exceptions will be made. Violations of this policy will result in the forfeiture of the Compliance Deposit. (See Fees and Stipends on last page.)

THE WEDDING REHEARSAL

Rehearsal day and time is usually pre-determined by the day and time of your wedding. Saturday weddings will have a **Friday evening rehearsal at 5:00 p.m.** It is important that rehearsals start on time and be completed by the end of the 45 minutes allotted for them. People taking part in the rehearsal or being present for it should remember that the rehearsal is taking

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place in an area dedicated to the worship of God. They should dress appropriately and arrive 15 minutes before the rehearsal time. **The use of alcoholic beverages at the church before, during or after the rehearsal is not permitted. Likewise, smoking is not allowed in any of the buildings. Food and drinks are also not permitted in the building.**

Please remind everyone that due to the heavy schedule of events in our parish, only 45 minutes are allowed for rehearsal and that the tardiness of anyone may shorten the time that you have to rehearse.

The rehearsal should involve the following:

Bride and Groom	Parents and Grandparents
Bridesmaids & Groomsmen	Readers
Ring bearer(s) / Flower girl(s)	Altar Servers
Ushers	
Gift bearers	

The wedding rehearsal is a brief, yet prayerful event where all of the above-mentioned individuals walk through their “cues” so that they will better understand the flow of the liturgy, thereby truly enjoying this blessed day. Accompanists, Cantors and other musicians are not normally present.

If any music rehearsals are requested outside of the hour preceding the wedding, arrangements must be made in advance between the Director of Sacred Music and all outside singer(s)/musician(s), and will be subject to availability of the church. Additional fees will be determined by the amount of extra time required for each musician.



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THE WEDDING DAY

The Church offers designated rooms in the Faith Formation building for the Bride and Groom and wedding party to prepare themselves. These rooms are available to you as follows:

Wedding – 90 minutes prior to the ceremony start time.

It is best to have ushers arrive already dressed. They should gather in the narthex to receive boutonnieres and await the beginning of the seating. **The entire wedding party should arrive at least 30 minutes prior to the beginning of the wedding.**

The Narthex doors at the back of Church remain closed until the Ushers begin seating your guests. This allows your guests to greet one another and visit prior to entering the Church itself. Please encourage your wedding party and guests to observe a reverent silence or hushed tone once in the worship space. The prelude music you choose should also assist the assembly in their prayerful preparation for liturgy.

Basic 'housekeeping' guidelines at St. Monica's:

- For everyone's safety, please do not allow anything to be thrown (e.g., birdseed, rice, flower petals or confetti) in the church or on the church grounds.
- Smoking is not permitted in the Church or Religious Education buildings.
- Consumption of alcohol is not permitted in the buildings or on the grounds. Consumption of alcohol by the bride and/or the groom before the ceremony will cause the postponement of the wedding.



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FEES AND STIPENDS

Church Fee

Registered Active Parishioners: Gift to Parish \$ _____

An “Active” Parishioner is defined by regular attendance at Mass, volunteer work in parish ministries and/or financial contribution on record at the parish for at least 6 months prior to scheduling the wedding date. Parishioners’ adult children and grandchildren are included as parishioners.

Newly Registered Parishioners, Inactive Registered Parishioners, or Non-Parishioners: \$2,000

Due 3 months prior to the date of the wedding.

Refundable Compliance Fee

\$300 - Due at the same time as the initial church deposit.

This fee is REFUNDABLE, after the wedding, if all rules and regulations are observed by the couple, the wedding party, vendors, etc. This includes, but is not limited to, photography, videotaping, smoking, alcohol, and time schedules. It is the responsibility of the wedding couple to make sure all parties involved (attendants, celebrants, family members, vendors, etc.) are aware of restrictions and regulations.

Celebrant’s Stipend

\$200.00 is the typical suggestion.

- *If someone other than the priest or deacon who officiated at your wedding assisted you with your marriage preparation, it is typical to extend a stipend to him as well.*

Musicians

Fees vary depending upon whom and how many musicians are involved in your ceremony. Here are some standard fees and guidelines:

- **All weddings require the services of an Accompanist and a Cantor**, and all fees below are the same for ceremonies with or without Mass.
- The stipend for musicians vary, please discuss with Jacob Temple
- Any music rehearsals requested by the couple that cannot be covered in the hour preceding before the wedding will incur additional fees for rehearsal time.
- The cantors/musicians involved will provide an estimate based on your needs.

Altar Servers

\$25.00 each (cash preferred since servers are children or teens. Envelope provided.)

There may be one to three servers at a Nuptial Mass, and only one at a ceremony without Mass.

Wedding Guild Coordinator

\$200.00, which is divided among the team. (Envelope provided.)

All fees are payable to the individuals working with you. Please do not make checks payable to *St. Monica’s*, except for your gift to the Parish.

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PLEASE NOTE: Rental of the parish hall for a reception is by separate contract and separate fee, and is not included in the cost of the wedding ceremony in the church. Rental of the parish hall is currently limited to Active Registered Parishioners only.

*Thank you and our prayers are with you at this joyful time in your lives.
May God bless your marriage and bring you great joy in the years to come!*